Mother Bats' Hearts Race for Their Own Babies

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A bat **colony** can have thousands of bats packed together. How does a mother bat find her own baby? Scientists in Japan found a clue in her heartbeat.

At Doshisha University, scientists noticed that when a baby bat, called a **pup**, wandered off, only its own mother rushed to help. **Pups** make special calls when they are alone, a bit like a baby crying.

The team recorded the **pups**' calls. Later, they played the sounds to four mother bats and measured their **heartbeats**.

The mothers' hearts beat faster when they heard their own **pups**, but not other bats' **pups**. Their hearts also sped up for a strange adult male bat. So a faster heartbeat does not show whether a mother feels caring or **alarmed**.

Still, the scientists think a **pup**'s call quickly gets a mother ready to take care of her baby.

Word Treasure

colony -- A big group of animals that live together.

pup -- A baby bat.

heartbeats -- The beats of the heart as it pumps blood.

alarmed -- Suddenly worried or scared.

Background you need

Bats are mammals, so mother bats take care of their babies, called pups.

In a crowded colony, a mother uses sound to find her own baby.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists at Doshisha University and mother bats
WHAT: Found mother bats' hearts beat faster for their own pups' calls
WHERE: In a lab in Japan
WHY: To learn how mothers find their babies in a crowded colony

Why it matters

Just like a parent can pick out their child's voice in a crowd, mother bats know their own babies by sound.

Test what you remember

1. What is a baby bat called?

- (A) A cub
- (B) A pup
- (C) A kitten
- (D) A chick

2. Where did the scientists work?

- (A) A zoo in Spain
- (B) Doshisha University in Japan
- (C) A farm in Canada
- (D) NASA

3. What happened when a pup wandered off?

- (A) Only its own mother rushed to help
- (B) All bats left
- (C) Nobody noticed
- (D) It flew to the Moon

4. How many mother bats were tested?

- (A) One hundred
- (B) Two
- (C) Four
- (D) Forty

5. When did mothers' hearts beat faster?

- (A) When they slept
- (B) When they ate
- (C) When it rained
- (D) When they heard their own pups

6. Why can't a faster heartbeat tell us exactly how a mother feels?

- (A) Bats have no hearts
- (B) The test was too short
- (C) It could mean caring or alarmed
- (D) Mothers were asleep

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):